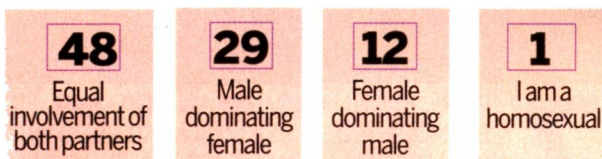


Models SHRUTI and AMIT ARORA

tual Michel Foucault's famous book, *Discipline and Punish*. Ideas of subservience lead us to an important part of the survey, that concerning the ideal kind of intimate relationships to which women and men aspire. To begin with, let's consider the information on oral sex. A higher percentage of men (64 per cent) than women (43 per cent) report 'doing' oral sex, and fewer women (32 per cent) than men (58 per cent) fantasise about it. Hence, it appears that that men may be getting their way more than women, and that women are less enthusiastic about trying it due to either male strictures or a lack of response from their partners. However, in response to another question, 46 per cent of men and 49 per cent of women said that they would prefer that both

SEPARATE BUT EQUAL

It takes two to tango. Almost half of the respondents believe sex is fun only when both partners have an equal stake in bedroom activities. A peep into India's sexual preferences.



Rest don't know/can't say. All figures in per cent.

49 PER CENT OF WOMEN RESPONDENTS PREFER AN EQUAL INVOLVEMENT OF BOTH PARTNERS WHILE HAVING SEX, COMPARED TO 46 PER CENT OF MEN.

the highest percentages (36 per cent and 26 per cent respectively). Indigenous items such as *elaichi* (cardamom) and *halwa* did not cut much ice with either men or women (though ice did, in several cities). The idea of 'good sex' is perhaps becoming increasingly tied to a transnational lifestyle, and hence to global goods such as chocolate sauce and ice-cream: so, *halwa* may well be suitable for indicating an attachment to 'tradition', but sexual modernity appears to require a post-*halwa* sensibility.

Speaking of post-*halwa* sensibility, what of those practices whose origin is, at least, in our times, quite clearly western, such as Bondage and Discipline Sadomasochism (BDSM)? A much higher percentage of men than women indicated that they would like to try BDSM (21 and 7 per cent respectively). Perhaps women already feel that they carry a large enough burden of being under male bondage and discipline in their everyday lives. This, however, does not explain why both men and women in Kolkata express above average enthusiasm for the practice: 69 per cent of men and 25 per cent of women reported as having tried it. It is not clear whether this is a survey quirk, or if Kolkata's reading circles have misunderstood the intent of the French intellec-

partners be 'equally involved' (rather than one 'dominating' the other) during sexual activity. Indeed, 61 per cent of men from Patna and 78 per cent from Kolkata were in favour of 'equal' involvement. So, it would appear that while the rhetoric of sexual democracy is well entrenched, it is yet to find a firm footing in practice. Nevertheless, it is intriguing that so many men, the traditionally powerful gender, would espouse the cause of equality in the present context: after all, this survey is an anonymous instrument and no one need know what you really thought.

What then of notion of fetishes as the 'dark continent' of sexuality that we began with? If there is one conclusion we might come to, it is that the survey tells us of a degree of comfort with discussing both one's private life as well as those aspects that might once have been considered aberrant. This is also a process of rethinking what constitutes aberrant and normal behaviour. These might be first steps towards ways of thinking about others and ourselves in terms other than black and white.

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